



Giant-killer: Japan has beaten multiple top-ranked nations, including Brazil and Argentina, in the run-up to the 2026 World Cup. AFP

expected to face strong resistance from Asian heavyweight Japan, which has discreetly built a reputation as a 'giant killer' since the last tournament in Qatar.

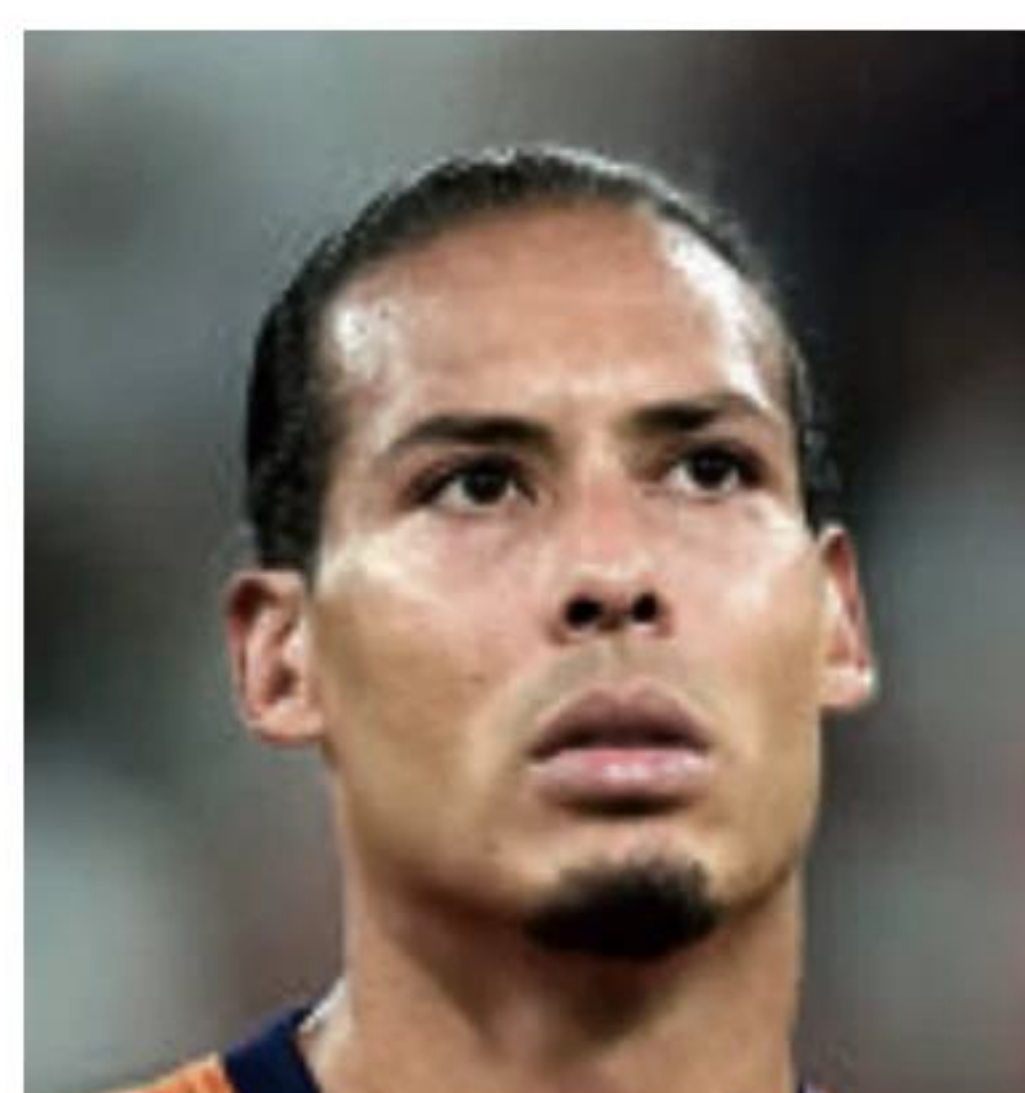
Placed in the 'group of death' with Germany and Spain, the Japanese contingent stunned both nations before bowing out in the round of 16 — a level yet to be crossed by the island nation.

Since that heartbreak, Japan has slain Germany again and, more recently, Brazil and England in international friendlies, underlining its pedigree on the world stage. It was the first nation apart from the hosts to book its place for this edition, dropping just seven points from a possible 48 in the qualifiers.

Head coach Hajime Moriyasu, however, will not have the services of European-proven players like Kaoru Mitoma or Takumi Minamino, who were both lost to injuries. But Ritsu Doan, Daichi Kamada and Takefusa Kubo, all of whom have had respectable seasons with their clubs, seem capable alternatives, while the defence will be buoyed by the inclusion of Yuto Nagatomo, who is set to travel to a fifth World Cup.

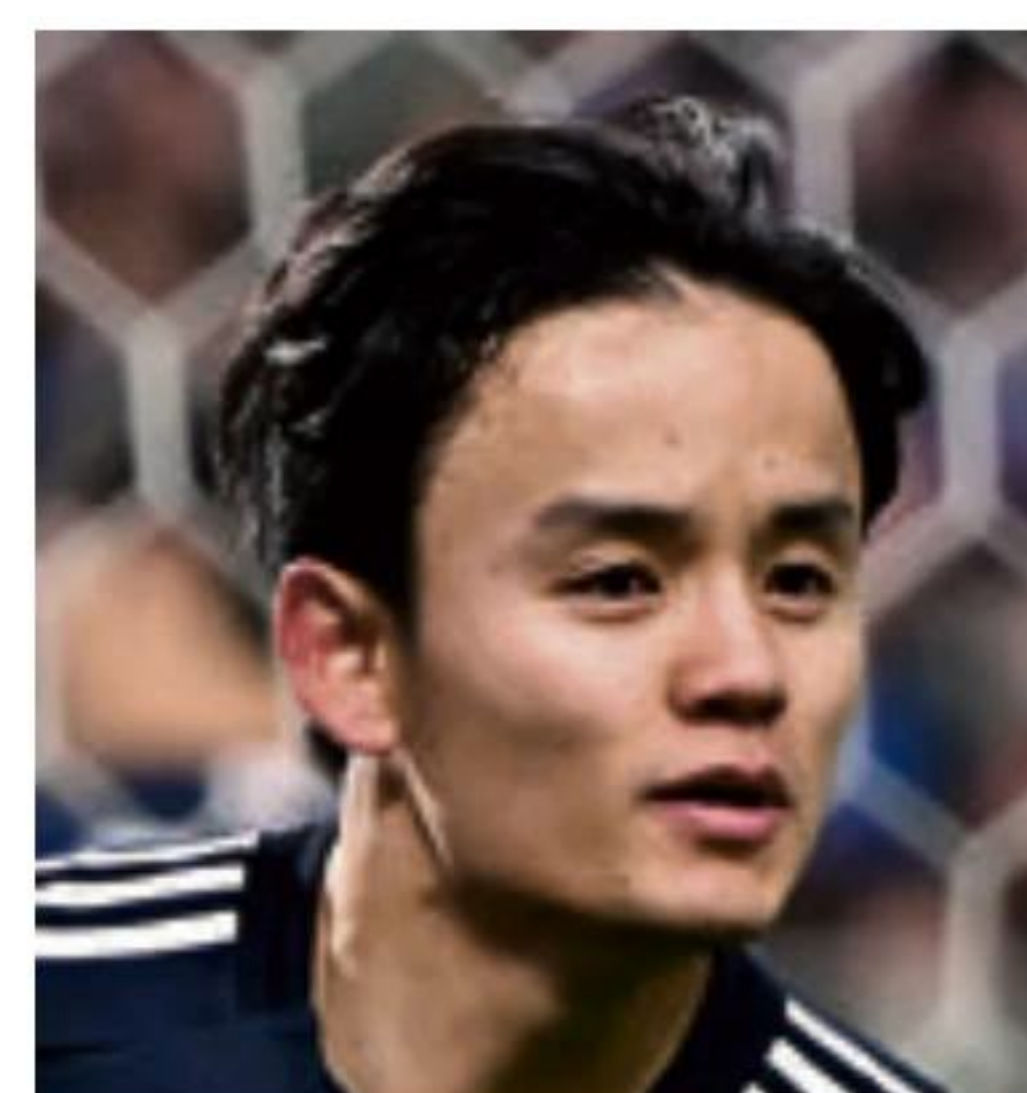
Meanwhile, Wataru Endo, who has started just one league game for Liverpool this season, is likely to don the captain's armband and could be the controlling figure in a team that relies on moving the ball around quickly to bypass

ON THE RADAR



Virgil van Dijk (Netherlands)

The towering Liverpool centre-back has come under the scanner several times this season, but no one can take away the fact that he remains one of the best in the business. Apart from being a menace to dribble past, the 34-year-old also provides an aerial threat from set pieces.



Takefusa Kubo (Japan)

Dubbed the 'Japanese Messi' from a young age, Takefusa Kubo has always had to carry a weight of expectation on his shoulders. This World Cup presents the perfect opportunity for him to live up to those claims, especially after a successful season in which he helped Real Sociedad lift the Copa del Rey.